while manufactured imports could be brought in cheaply. In many places, the traditional artisan economy suffered a major shock even as the old caravan routes became redundant. The Marwari merchants of Rajasthan, for instance, were forced to leave their homes and look for opportunities in the new world. Many would make their way to Calcutta where their descendants would become very successful businessmen. Their semi-abandoned but beautifully frescoed ancestral homes can still be seen in towns like Mandawa and Jhunjhunu in the Shekhawati region of Rajasthan.

Meanwhile, new towns sprouted along the railway routes even as some communities took advantage of their rapid expansion. One such group was the racially mixed Anglo-Indian (i.e. Eurasian) community that joined the railways in large numbers. They created a colourful sub-culture that has faded away in recent decades. I remember how, when I was growing up in the early 1980s, there was still a strong Anglo-Indian community in Kolkata, with its distinctive cuisine, its love of music and sport, and somewhat idiosyncratic use of the English language. Today, a few pockets remain but the Anglo-Indians are increasingly indistinguishable from the wider Indian Christian population. There is a sizeable diaspora in Australia and Canada, where too it has increasingly integrated with the wider society. Nevertheless, the memory of the old Anglo-Indian community remains alive in novels and films such as John Masters's *Bhowani Junction*. Writer Carl Muller's trilogy about the Burghers of Sri Lanka is a humorous account of the lives and attitudes of this disappearing world. [16]

As a linkage technology, the railway system was the Internet or mobile network of its time. As it carried people and goods across the country, it allowed a new form of interaction between different parts of the subcontinent. The social reformer and religious leader Swami Vivekananda used trains to criss-cross the country in the last decade of the nineteenth century. Mahatma Gandhi would do the same as he tried to re-acquaint himself with India after his return from South Africa. By 1924, 576 million passenger trips were being made per year. Of course, this does not mean that train journeys were always enjoyable, especially for the second- and